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INDIA'S DEFENCE ECOSYSTEM AND THE UKRAINE CONFLICT

A possible disruption in the future supplies of spares is an opportunity to speed up self-reliance through indigenous arms production

America continues to heckle India to reduce defence and energy relations with Russia, while simultaneously cosying up to Pakistan. Meanwhile, Germany wants Kashmir raked up at the UN. The fallout of the Ukraine conflict on India's military preparedness remains in discussion, with the US 'using' Ukraine to battle Russia and not wanting the conflict to end till Russia's war-waging potential is reduced to its liking.

Indo-Russian defence relations have remained steadfast over the decades. In December 2021, both countries inked a 10-year defence cooperation pact and signed 28 agreements. Some 70 per cent of Indian armed forces equipment is of Russian origin including some under licensed production, the majority of which is held by the army followed by the air force and navy.

Russia is exporting the S-400 missile system to India. The delivery is on time and all five regiments are expected by 2023. BrahMos Aerospace Ltd has begun exporting BrahMos missiles to foreign countries, and is developing the BrahMos-NG and the BrahMos-II hypersonic cruise missile. AK-203 assault rifles are also being produced in India with Russian collaboration. The third Akula-class submarine Chakra III on a 10-year lease from Russia is also expected by 2025.

There have been concerns about the supply of spares from Ukraine for some of the tanks and missile systems in our army, as also gas turbine engines for the Talwar class frigates contracted from Russia. However, India independently contracted gas turbine engines from Ukraine to resolve the issue. The army reportedly has enough spares for the tanks and missile systems. Russia has also assured no disruption in supplies.

The defence establishment has been reviewing the likely impact of a prolonged Ukraine conflict, coupled with ambiguous Chinese intentions—the People's Liberation Army (PLA) has not vacated areas of eastern Ladakh seized in 2020. However, possible disruption in future supplies of spares should be seen as an opportunity to speed up self-reliance through indigenous production and Make in India.

GETTY IMAGES



ENDLESS WAR
A blast site in Kyiv, Ukraine, Oct. 10

According to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) study 'Arms Production Capabilities in the Indo-Pacific Region: Measuring Self-Reliance' released on October 3, India's target of defence exports worth Rs 35,000 crore by 2025 can be achieved by doubling procurement from domestic manufacturers. The study ranked India fourth in the Indo Pacific and states, 'Maintaining local arms manufacturing and repair capabilities allows states to sustain their forces' equipment in case of supply disruptions and provides limited capability for military adaptation and innovation.' We should be focusing on voids in indigenous development like aero and gas turbine engines for naval warships. With no end to the Ukraine conflict in sight, the feasibility of indigenous production of spares in conjunction with Russia could be examined.

Is the clout of the public sector compared to the private defence industry slowing our self-sufficiency in defence? Can we afford to continue bureaucratic indifference towards operational priorities? Witness how the procurement of six submarines under Project P-75I has been stuck at the RFP stage for years. Looking at the chain of events since 1997 when the defence ministry approved the acquisition of 24 submarines, there appears little urgency despite increasing maritime threats in the region.

Similarly, the 'Strategic Partnership' model is yet to take off and the 'offsets' clause has seen much success, indicating poor implementation and, perhaps, forethought. Decisions about modes of procurement and procurement procedures are changed periodically, there is no effort to cut down red tape and the fact that this delay results in exponentially higher procurement costs is ignored, perhaps by design.

India developed NavIC after the US switched off GPS during the Kargil conflict to prevent the Indian Navy from blockading the Karachi harbour. Similarly, we should aim to create a defence ecosystem in conjunction with Russia and others to remain unaffected by a prolonged Ukraine conflict. Our defence relationship with Russia remains important also because it is a reliable friend compared to the US, which has a history of 'using and throwing' countries despite the pretence of friendship. ■

The author is a Special Forces veteran